

Learning to Survive

Denied salaries for the last two years, teachers in the state's unaided schools are worse off than daily-wage labourers

In ancient India, gurus were held in high regard because, as the scriptures said, the teachers enlightened the world. Modern India seems to have made a clean break from the past, especially in Uttar Pradesh, where over one lakh teachers in more than 20,000 unaided primary and junior schools have been reduced to penury because of a peculiar provision that has cut off their salaries for the last two years.

"We are worse off than even convicted criminals who at least get wages while working in jail," rues Durg Vijay Singh, president of the Uttar Pradesh Senior Basic Teachers Sangh. He is referring to what are classified as "unaided" schools. They have been recognised by the government but at the end of the month, they are denied salaries because they have not been included in the list of "aided schools".

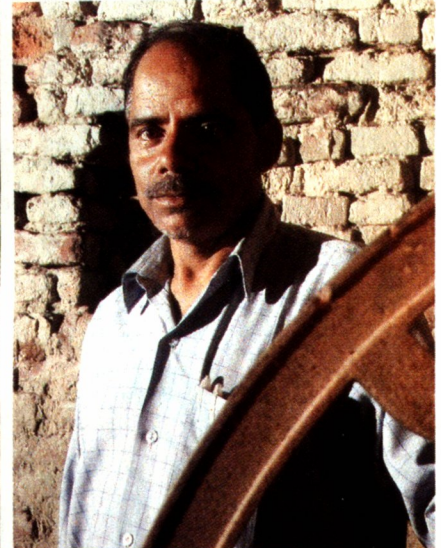
In the last decade, only 1,000 schools out of over 20,000 have been included in the category of aided schools. But even some of the aided schools are not getting funds because of procedural issues. The Sangh has made efforts to draw the attention of Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati by submitting petitions, but the exercise remains unproductive. Ironically, all recent chief ministers—Mayawati, Mulayam Singh Yadav, Kalyan Singh and Rajnath Singh—have been teachers before they joined politics but none has come to the aid of their former colleagues. "Before our school was included in the aided category, we were getting only Rs 400 to Rs 500 a month," said Ram Karan, a teacher from Sarwan village. But now, even that is gone as the school management says it is for the government to pay the salaries.

Meanwhile, lakhs of teachers face

starvation and humiliation. "Tragically, a large number of teachers, who failed to get salaries even after working for 10-20 years, have already died. There have been instances of many ending their lives in frustration," says Singh. Not only teachers, even non-teaching staff have been de-

and the state Government are spending thousands of crores just to improve primary education in the state, but most have chosen to ignore the pathetic conditions of the teachers who cater to the rural population. In 1998, Justice Markandey Katju, while hearing a petition in connection with the non-payment of teachers' salaries, in the Allahabad High Court, observed that whoever is opening a school in a rural area is doing a great service to the nation, and the state must pay salaries to

IN DISTRESS: Ram Narayan Yadav (left) and Ram Karan



AID FOR THE UNAIDED A LONG WAY OFF

After opening a school and getting government recognition for it, the school management applies for government aid to disburse salary to the teaching and non-teaching staff. The government keeps on denying the aided category status to these schools in order to save funds. For this, the state's Basic Education Department keeps picking out irregularities, forcing the schools to make umpteen rounds of the education office. These tactics by the government create two categories of schools—aided and unaided.

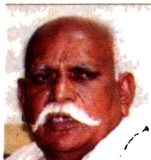
nied salaries and a number of them have taken up jobs like carpentry or washing clothes to earn their livelihood. Ram Narayan Yadav, 48, from Sarwan village in Unnao district, who has been teaching for more than 20 years, survives by selling buffalo milk.

It is a paradox that the Government of India, international funding agencies

the teachers. Instead of following the court directions, the state government got a stay on this order.

To add insult to injury, the government continues to grant recognition to new primary and junior schools even though it is unable to take care of the existing ones, says Tapeshwari Pandey, a primary school teacher from Azamgarh. "The tragedy is that a teacher is getting Rs 500 a month while a roadside labourer earns Rs 3,000," he says. The teachers have learnt a hard lesson—they just aren't a large enough vote bank.

by Subhash Mishra



"There have been instances of teachers, who were not paid, ending their lives in frustration."

DURG VIJAY SINGH, PRESIDENT, UP SENIOR BASIC TEACHERS SANGH